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Research Topic: Investigating the Role of Social Media in Promoting Consumer Culture: A Case Study of Adolescents (Ages 14-19) in Bali, Indonesia

1.0 Introduction

Escalating social media trends plague users daily, creating more expectations for social media users, especially adolescents, to conform. Recently, online, users feel the pressure to explain and define themselves as a way to unleash their most authentic self, often expressed by indulging in certain niches and aesthetics that differ from others and are personal. Erving Goffman developed the dramaturgy approach to explain social interactions as corresponding to theatrical performances, where individuals display curated behaviors, interests, and expressions to control how they are perceived [1]. Individuals demand that others associate them with certain attributes that they appear to possess [2]. For this reason, individuals participate in trends, hobbies, and interests that align with their desired identity. Marketing strategies and tailored advertisements reinforce this by feeding into online users' algorithms, presenting them as personalized and made specifically for them. Often, these curated forms of identity are served in the form of goods and products, making the only way to embody their "true identity" is through constant purchasing and consumption. While research on capitalism and psychological crises saturates the field, it often fails to question the capitalist structures that sustain these psychological crises [3]. This research aims to identify how the pressures and demands of defining one's identity to be "unique" and "true to self" regulate consumer culture. Therefore, this research compares the expenses, identity perceptions, and psychological well-being of Balinese, Indonesian users aged 14-19 with >5 hours of social media screen time with those of users with <2 hours of social media screen time.

2.0 Literature Review

Capitalism is necessarily built on three intrinsic principles: profit motive, market competition, and private property ownership [4]. These three fundamental principles correspond to users' behavior of: the urge for continuous capital accumulation, the obligative culture to outcompete others by embodying the "most unique", and the impulsive behavior of purchasing and owning products to display an identity. In this digital age, Indonesia's citizens were reported to average 143 million active users by late 2025, ranking third in Asia Pacific [5]. Bali ranked third in the highest internet penetration of 91.8% [6] and fifth for having the most entrepreneurship population in Indonesia [7]. Social media endorses material-driven identity by directly relating personal value to material possessions, constructing an individualist culture [4]. The internet is a fast-paced, saturated medium that floods its users with a catalog of aesthetics to choose from. Content creators religiously upload ways to romanticize life by indulging in expensive treats; romanticizing life is no longer an act of valuing life experiences, but rather immersing in excessive consumption to make life "a bit better".

Capitalists impose pressures for their own capital gain, which effectively dictates individuals' perceptions of themselves and their social lives: the Gain Primacy Syndrome [3]. This occurs when influencers and businesses create new marketing terms, aesthetics, and small subcultures that people can identify with. As seen in the reduction of subcultures merely into styles that strip them of their distinct values, labels are not only an additional feature of our identity but

potentially act as the perfect guide to reach one's true identity by dismissing its core beliefs and only engaging with its material possessions.

Carl Jung coined the "persona," which refers to the social mask of the collective psyche worn by an actor, replacing individuality, posing for others and themselves to believe they are their persona [8]. When an individual over-identifies with their persona, it will be embroidered too deeply in their unconscious that they will, most likely, experience an internal disconnection with their authentic self – resulting in depression and anxiety. Potentially, they mistake their persona for individuation by thinking that the social mask they put on is their most authentic self, but in reality it is just a fabricated facade shown off intentionally to the public. Individuals would not be able to escape from social rules and expectations, boxed in with a list of behaviors they ought to follow. When they deviate from these criteria, they may experience a sense of crisis, questioning who they truly are because the label no longer feels acceptable or fitting. Whoever aligns most closely with their collective psyche is nearest to their most desirable image, yet they are in the least liberated realm [8]. Erving Goffman labels performers' 'front' as an intentional, definitive tool that performers utilize during their acts around observers. He then refined this theory by using the term 'personal front' to refer to vital objects in play with the 'front'. These are the objects observers most associate with the performer and the performance, as they shadow the performer everywhere they go [2]. Therefore, to link this theory to the research aim, online users who label themselves with a particular identity adopt a personal front through personal property (e.g., clothes, accessories, cosmetics, and other goods). This does not alleviate the struggle of capitalism; instead, it proliferates it through the purchase of unnecessary goods to make their act seem believable and real to others.

Despite a brimming amount of empirical studies on social media and its impacts on adolescents' mental health, it often fails to put capitalism into the picture. Consumer culture and materialism may trigger momentary pleasure and happiness; however, in the long term, it directly legitimizes low self-confidence and the pressure of acceptance through validation. Materialistic individuals were reported to have reduced levels of happiness due to the rejection of nurturing experiences that yield happiness, encompassing relationships or meaningful experiences [9]. In reality, capitalism is the DNA of society that interacts with and instructs most cultures we study. By overlooking capitalism when studying mental health crises, we have unconsciously condoned its palpable damage to psychological well-being as intrinsic to life [3]. This study, therefore, addresses a critical gap in psychological research by investigating how capitalistic values in social media undermine users' perception of identity, which amplifies consumer culture and declining mental well-being.

3.0 Research Questions and Aims

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This research aims to investigate the significant role of social media in shaping adolescents' perceptions of their identity by portraying identity as a consumer good. In this sense, the research hopes to address the following questions:

1. How does an individual's perception of what shapes identity differ with different hours of social media usage?

2. In what ways, and to what extent, does an individual spend on materialistic goods to express their "identity"?
3. Does consumerist behavior link with low self-esteem and emotional well-being?

4.0 Methodology

9 **4.1 Research Design:** This research uses a mixed-methods approach, applying both quantitative and qualitative methods to assess how effective social media is in shaping individuals' perceptions of identity, which links to the culture of consumerism and signs of low self-esteem. Most data will be gathered through primary methods, such as interviews and personal reports. Personal reports will be written over a three-month period (qualitative method), and multiple assessments will be used to operationalize variables (quantitative), such as emotional well-being and self-esteem. To ensure reliability, the same quantitative tests and interview questions will be used before and after the three months. Qualitative data will be evaluated using thematic analysis, categorizing responses into themes that help researchers understand participants' materialistic
13 values, the role of social media in daily life, and perceptions of identity. To analyze quantitative data, a parametric test of an independent t-Test will be used to compare two independent samples (sample group with >1 hour screen time versus sample group with <5 hours screen time) and test for statistical differences.

1 **4.2 Sampling Method:** The sampling frame includes 200 participants, ages 14-19. Essentially,
1 the sample will be divided equally into two independent groups: reportedly an average of <2 hours of social media screen time and >5 hours of social media screen time. The sample will be collected through volunteer sampling: advertised to different high schools and universities in Bali, Indonesia. To ensure representativeness, selected participants will, more or less, include a fair number of people from each gender, school, and age.

4.3 Measurement Tools: This research will employ a triangulation approach of both quantitative and qualitative methods to effectively address the following variables:

- **A.** Self-esteem: standardized Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (RSE) to be repeated before and after the study.
- **B.** Emotional well-being: PERMA Profiler questionnaire to be repeated before and after the study.
- **C.** Spending: participants will write a self-report over three months documenting every purchase they made, with documentation of the exact amount, price, and a brief explanation as to why they spent their money.
- **D.** Personal views and values: participants will be interviewed before and after the study using a standardized, open-ended questionnaire to investigate identity perception, materialistic values, and the overall role of social media.

4.4 Data Analysis

Quantitative Analysis: We will employ an independent t-Test to compare two independent groups
1 1 (participants reporting an average of <2 hours of social media screen time and >5 hours of social

media screen time) on their spending and overall score in the self-esteem and emotional well-being tests. We will then test the output for homogeneity of variance using Levene's Test.

Qualitative Analysis: Interview transcripts will be interpreted using thematic analysis to identify themes and patterns in the two sample groups regarding their values and identity perception with the influence of social media.

4.5 Ethical Considerations: This research will collect parental consent for participants under the age of 18 and their own voluntary consent. Participants should sign a consent form agreeing to core psychological ethics principles: protection from harm, valid consent, right to withdraw, confidentiality, deception, privacy, and debriefing.

5.0 Timeline

1. Participants who have been successfully recruited by following the ethical guidelines and participant requirements will be debriefed about the study with clear instructions on what to do.
2. The study begins with pre-tests and interviews to act as their baseline for identifying significant changes after the study.
3. Participants write in their personal report as told during the three months. Both sample groups should try to maintain similar social media screen time to what was reported when recruited during the three months to ensure validity in the findings.
4. After the three months, participants hand in their personal report, followed by the same tests and interview that were once conducted at the beginning of the study.

6.0 Expected Outcome: We expect that there will be distinguishable spending patterns between the two sample groups, with the sample group of >5 hours of social media screen time having saturated spending on materialistic goods. This outcome is predicted because of the extensive use of social media, exposure to large amounts of marketing strategies, and its noteworthy influence on participants' daily lives. Meanwhile, the sample group with <2 hours of social media screen time will score higher in self-esteem and well-being tests due to the lack of internet culture influences.

7.0 Limitations: This research may lack internal validity, as spending patterns of each participant may be influenced by other factors, such as socioeconomic group, status, and availability. Thus, it is unclear whether the changes in the dependent variables measured are solely caused by the independent variable (social media usage).

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